BIHAR

# WANTED NO MORE

By Amitabh Srivastava

On July 18, the same day as over two dozen constituents of the national Opposition front came together in Bengaluru for their second conclave, Rajesh Ranjan, alias Pappu Yadav, one of the most popular don-turned-politicians in Bihar and five-term Lok Sabha MP, was dejectedly addressing a press conference in Patna to express hurt over not being invited to the meeting. Yadav, who heads the Jan Adhikar Party (JAP) and enjoys clout in the Kosi region, recounted how he had appealed to Bihar chief minister and Janata Dal-United (JD-U) supremo Nitish Kumar, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) boss Lalu Yadav, and even the Congress for entry into the state's Mahagathbandhan (MGB) fold, only to be ungraciously snubbed. It was just last year that the Congress had nominated his wife Ranjeet Ranjan to the Rajya Sabha—but then, as a forceful orator in Parliament, she has an independent political existence.

It's rough weather for Bihar's once-powerful bahubalis these days. Part-Robinhoods, part-caste lords, part-social influencers and part-musclemen, today they find themselves being cast aside ahead of the 2024 polls, partly thanks to Nitish's split with the BJP last year and his alliance with the Congress, RJD and the Left. It's more a course in logic than ethics, though. The move altered Bihar's political theatre, turning it into a two-front battle between the MGB and the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) and consequently shrinking the space for such 'one-man armies'. So, apart from Yadav, there is also former MLA Anant Singh a.k.a. Chhote Sarkar, the once-prized strongman now left twiddling his thumbs in Patna's Beur central jail after his conviction in an Arms Act case. Incidentally, the RJD had just last year backed Singh's wife Neelam Devi for the Mokama assembly bypoll after her husband's disqualification, and she even won the election. As for the controversial release of convicted killer and politician Anand Mohan Singh in April, if there was any speculation that the MGB would welcome him in a bid to sway Rajputs away from the BJP, nothing has materialised so far, with no prominent politician seen rubbing shoulders with him.

In the same spirit, if the MGB has turned its back on the likes of Pappu Yadav, Anant Singh and Anand Mohan Singh, the NDA has slammed its door shut on political profiteers like Mukesh Sahani, the Vikassheel Insaan Party (VIP) chief. Though the saffron party is believed to have made some initial overtures to him, those didn't lead to an invite for the NDA meeting in July, reportedly because the group can't spare the number of seats the ambitious Sahani is seeking. "An acutely clear two-front battle has its advantages," says a BJP leader. "For instance, even the fence-sitters or somewhat disillusioned supporters choose to back their parties, as

## OUT IN THE COLD

**The 'one-man armies' in Bihar who have found no takers ahead of the 2024 polls**



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**ANANT SINGH, 56**

Singh was a man in favour in the 2019 general election when Congress fielded his wife Neelam Devi from Munger, with Tejashwi Yadav even campaigning for her. But disqualified last year after his conviction in an Arms Act case, he has been left high and dry. It's unlikely that the MGB or the Congress will field his MLA wife in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls